

The name comes from Henok, or Enoch, one of the great patriarchs of the Bible. Henok was Methuselah's father and Noah's grandfather. He was said to have lived to be 365 years old.

The family businesses that are invited to join this group have been in business for at least 200 years. (For this reason, it's also known as *l'Association d'Entreprises Familiales et Bicentenaires*.) Other membership criteria include:

- The family must be the owner or majority shareholder of a company.
- One member of the founding family must still manage the company or be a member of the board.
- The company must be financially successful, with annual revenues of more than \$2 million.

There are currently 38 members from around the world. The oldest member is a Japanese family business called Hoshi Ryokan, a traditional Japanese inn founded beside a hot spring in 718.

The northern Italian Beretta family is also a member. The family has been making guns since 1526. Everyone knows the name.

The Mellerio family has been making jewelry since the early 1600s. The Barovier family has been blowing glass on the Venetian island of Murano since the 1400s. And one French winemaking member family also makes their own oak casks. (One of their casks dates from 1715 and is still in daily use.)

Every member family has a story—and an amazing history. Think of the change that has happened over the past 200 years. These businesses have survived every calamity you can imagine.

Having read all their profiles and a number of interviews with the current managers, a few things jumped out at us.

First, the managers of these businesses, rooted in history and tradition, saw entrepreneurship and innovation as key to their success. For the business to last, there has to be a wealth creator in each generation.

Incredibly, most of the families still own 100 percent of their companies. They are extremely protective of the family equity. And some had established restrictions on family members selling out of the business.

This is contrary to what you might read in family wealth books, in which they tell you to let family members be able to sell out. To preserve